

Customer Support SLA and Escalation Handbook

Document owner: Customer Operations
Department: Customer Operations
Version: 2026.1
Effective date: 2026-01-01

Document owner: Customer Operations Department: Customer Operations Version: 2026.1 Effective date: 2026-01-01

Purpose

This handbook defines how quickly TraceStock AI responds to customer contacts, how cases are prioritised, when a case must be escalated, and what a support agent may decide without approval. It complements the Return and Refund Policy, which governs outcomes; this document governs process and timing.

Contact Channels

Customers reach support through four routes. Response commitments differ by route because customer expectations differ.

Channel	First response target	Resolution target	Hours
Email	8 business hours	3 business days	Mon-Fri 08:00-18:00 CET
Web form	8 business hours	3 business days	Mon-Fri 08:00-18:00 CET
Phone	Answered within 3 minutes	Same call where possible	Mon-Fri 09:00-17:00 CET
Marketplace messaging	24 hours	3 business days	Platform rules override

Marketplace platforms impose their own response requirements. Where a platform requires a faster response than this handbook, the platform requirement applies and takes precedence.

Case Priority Levels

Every case receives a priority at first touch. Priority determines the response commitment, not the order in which the case was received.

P1: Safety or legal. Any report of injury, fire, electrical fault, or regulatory complaint. Also any contact from a lawyer or consumer authority. First response within 2 hours. Escalate to Quality and to the Head of Customer Operations immediately. Never close without a documented outcome.

P2: Financial or high value. Refund disputes, duplicate charges, orders over 1,000 EUR, or any b2b account issue. First response within 4 business hours. Manager review before any refund above the agent limit.

P3: Standard. Return requests within policy, delivery questions, product questions, exchange requests. Standard SLA applies.

P4: Informational. Stock availability, product comparison, general policy questions. Standard SLA applies, may be answered from documentation.

A case may be re-prioritised upward at any time. It may only be re-prioritised downward with a note explaining why.

Agent Decision Authority

Support agents may decide the following without approval:

- Accept a return within the standard 30-calendar-day window where the product

condition rules are met

- Issue a refund to the original payment method up to 250 EUR
- Approve an exchange of equal or lesser value
- Waive return shipping cost where the company caused the error
- Extend a return window by up to 5 calendar days where the customer provides

evidence of delayed delivery

Agents may not decide the following without a manager:

- Refunds above 250 EUR
- Refunds outside the return window
- Refunds without proof of purchase
- Any goodwill credit above 100 EUR
- Any case involving a safety claim
- Any deviation from the Return and Refund Policy

Attempting to resolve a case by splitting it into smaller refunds to stay under an approval threshold is treated as a policy breach.

Escalation Matrix

Situation	Escalate to	Timeframe
Safety or injury claim	Quality, plus Head of Customer Operations	Immediately
Suspected product defect pattern	Quality	Same day
Refund dispute above 250 EUR	Customer Operations Manager	Within 4 hours
Repeated returns from one customer	Fraud review	Within 1 business day

Situation	Escalate to	Timeframe
Stock or delivery failure affecting many orders	Fulfillment	Same day
Legal or regulatory contact	Head of Customer Operations	Immediately
b2b account dispute	Commercial	Within 1 business day

Escalation means transferring ownership with a written summary. Forwarding a message without context is not escalation and does not stop the SLA clock.

Response Quality Standards

Every response must state what will happen next and by when. A response that acknowledges the problem without committing to an action does not count as a first response for SLA purposes.

Responses must be specific about amounts, dates, and conditions. "We will refund you shortly" is not acceptable; "We will refund 89.99 EUR to your original card within 5 business days of receiving the item" is.

Where a request is refused, the response must state the policy basis and the route to challenge it. Refusing without a reason generates repeat contacts and escalations.

Repeat Contact Handling

If a customer contacts support a third time about the same case, the case is automatically escalated to a manager regardless of value or priority. Repeat contact usually indicates the first response failed to resolve or failed to explain, and continuing at the same level rarely helps.

Repeat contacts are tracked per case, not per customer. A customer with three separate cases has not triggered this rule.

Difficult Situations

Customer disputes a policy that was correctly applied. Explain the policy, state the specific clause, and offer the escalation route. Do not change the outcome to end the conversation.

Customer is abusive. One warning, then end the contact and record it. Abusive contact does not remove the customer's rights under the return policy, and their case must still be resolved on its merits.

Customer claims a promise that is not recorded. Check the record. If nothing supports the claim, say so plainly and offer resolution within policy. Do not assert the customer is lying, and do not honour unrecorded promises above the goodwill limit.

The company made an error. Acknowledge it directly, fix it, and cover any cost the customer incurred as a result. Errors caused by the company are not subject to the standard return window.

Metrics

Customer Operations is measured on:

- First response within SLA, target 95 percent
- Resolution within SLA, target 90 percent
- Repeat contact rate, target below 12 percent

- Escalation rate, target below 8 percent
- Cases closed without a documented outcome, target zero

A high escalation rate is not automatically a problem. Escalating a case that should be escalated is correct. Closing a case that should have been escalated is the failure being measured against.

Document Control

Field	Value
Version	2026.1
Effective date	2026-01-01
Last reviewed	2026-01-01
Next review due	2027-01-01
Owner	Customer Operations
Approved by	Head of Customer Operations
Classification	Internal

This document is reviewed annually, and sooner if a change in law, supplier arrangement, or operating practice makes part of it inaccurate. The version published internally is the controlled copy; printed copies are uncontrolled. Proposed changes go to the document owner.